

Gender and Identity

Biology, Roles, and Culture

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Understanding Gender in Development and in Context

Sex and gender are deeply embedded in Western identity

Conversations about gender are now more open and widely accepted than in the past

Gender ambiguity and gender change are increasingly common

- Language around biology, gender, and identity
 - Science recognizes far greater biological and social variation
 - Many still believe gender is fixed and unchangeable
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Gender and Sex

Sex / Gender are often used interchangeably but have different meanings

Sex — genes and biological development that determine male or female;
Think rooted in biology

Gender — social differentiation into masculine or feminine shaped by culture;
Think rooted in culture

- **Gender identity** — personal sense of being a boy/man or girl/woman
 - **Gender role** — social expectations of masculinity and femininity
 - **Cisgender** — person whose behaviors and gender identity align with; a man with a masculine identity or a woman with a feminine identity.
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Gender and Sex

Genetic sex — chromosomal and hormonal sex characteristics; XX or XY and estrogen or testosterone dominant

Anatomical sex — biological attributes of physiology and reproductive organs (vagina, penis)

Assigned female-at-birth or assigned male-at-birth — used to categorize bodies based on external genital anatomy

Biological Processes in the Development of Sex

Sexual differentiation — process of developing into male or female, starting before conception and continuing during fetal development

Ovum and sperm both carry sex chromosomes

- **Ovum** — X chromosome
- **Sperm** — X or Y chromosome
- **Chromosome combinations** — XY → male; XX → female

In fetal development, external genitals of males and females develop from the *same tissues*

Figure 9.1 Micrographs of the sex chromosomes



Figure 9.2 The process of sexual differentiation during prenatal development

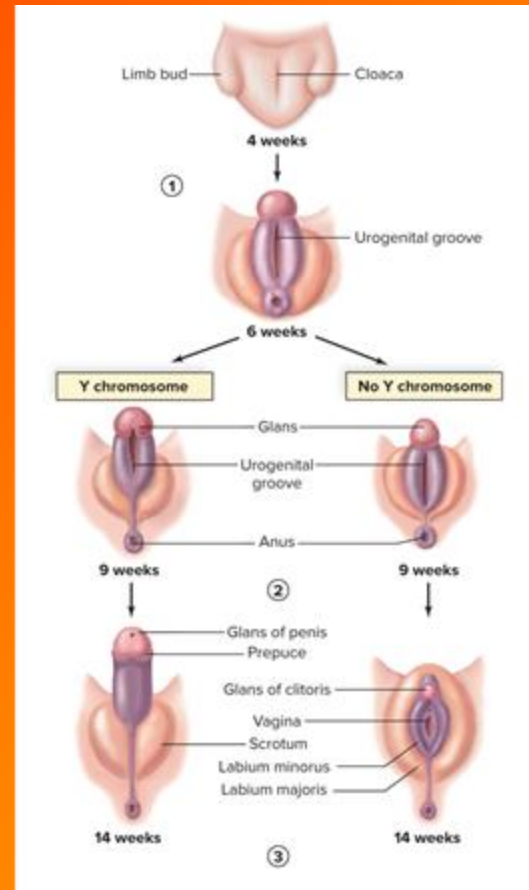


Table 9.1 Sex differentiation as a biological process— prenatal differentiation

CHARACTERISTIC	FEMALE	MALE
Chromosomal sex	XX	XY
Gonadal sex	Ovaries	Testes
Hormonal sex	Estrogens; Pregestational compounds.	Androgens
Internal reproductive structures	Fallopian tubes; Uterus; Cervix; Inner portions of vagina.	Vas deferens; Seminal vesicles; Ejaculatory ducts; Prostate.
External genitals	Vulva, which includes the clitoris, inner labia (labia minora), vaginal opening (introitus), and outer labia (labia majora)	Penis; Scrotum.
Sex differentiation of the brain	Hypothalamus becomes estrogen sensitive, influencing cyclic release of hormones. Two hypothalamic areas are smaller in the female brain. Cerebral cortex of right hemisphere is thinner in the female brain. Corpus callosum is thicker in the female brain. Less lateralization of function in the female brain compared to the male brain.	Estrogen-sensitive male hypothalamus directs steady production of hormones. Two hypothalamic areas are larger in the male brain. Cerebral cortex of right hemisphere is thicker in the male brain. Corpus callosum is thinner in the male brain. More lateralization of function in the male brain compared to the female brain.

Biological Sex Variations and Intersex People

Sexual dimorphism — being either female or male

- Does not account for all variation among human bodies



Biological Sex Variations and Intersex People

Intersexuality — condition of being biologically between male and female

- Chromosomal, genital, and gonadal
 - Biological characteristics of both the male and female sexes.
 - **Virilization** — masculinization of the body and genital structures
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Table 9.2 Summary of biological intersex variations

CHROMOSOMES	BIOLOGICAL INTERSEX VARIATION	DESCRIPTION
XX	Congenital adrenal hyperplasia (CAH)	The most common cause of sexual ambiguity in individuals with XX sex chromosomes.
XX	Progestin-induced virilization	This condition of individuals with XX sex chromosomes is caused by the mother's use of progestin, a drug used in the 1950s and 1960s to prevent miscarriage.
XY	Androgen insensitivity syndrome (AIS)	This occurs in approximately 1 in 20,000 individuals when the cells of the body are unable to respond to androgen, so they have a Y chromosome (typically XY) but their body is unable to masculinize, which results in them having female appearance and genitalia.
XXY	Klinefelter syndrome	A condition in which a person inherits an extra X chromosome from either the father or mother. It occurs in about 1 in 500, or approximately 550,000 people in the United States.
XYY	XYY syndrome	A rare chromosomal disorder caused by the presence of an extra Y chromosome that affects males in about 1 in 1,000 births. The affected individuals are typically very tall.
XXX	Triple X syndrome	A condition characterized by the presence of an additional X chromosome in each of a female's cells. AKA trisomy X or 47,XXX syndrome.
XO	Turner syndrome	A rare condition in which a female does not have the usual XX sex chromosomes.
XY	5-alpha-reductase deficiency	A rare condition that occurs in genetic males. It occurs in much higher incidence in inbreeding communities.

Biological Sex Variations and Intersex People

Klinefelter syndrome — males have one or more extra X chromosomes (47,XXY)

- May express some female traits

Figure 9.3

Common characteristics of individuals with Klinefelter syndrome

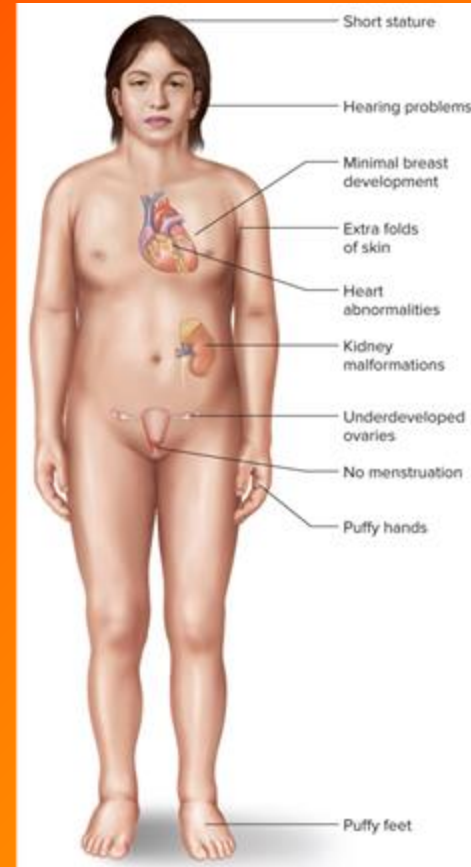


Biological Sex Variations and Intersex People

Turner syndrome — female does not have the usual pair of two X chromosomes (45,X)

Figure 9.4

Common characteristics of individuals with Turner syndrome



Gender Identity and Expression

Gender binary — perception that sex and gender are either male or female

- Sex and gender exist on a spectrum

Gender expression — how people express their gender through behavior, clothes, hair, voice, gait.

- May adhere or violate cultural expectations
 - Individualized
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Gender Identity—A Brief History

Historically, gender was seen as the foundation of self-awareness and unchangeable

- Viewed as fixed and never questioned
 - Contemporary theorists question this perspective
 - What about psychological and behavioral influence on gender?
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Gender Identity—A Brief History

Early cases of gender affirmation surgeries were all male to female.

- Example — Christine Jorgensen in the 1950s

Today, females can transition to a male to affirm gender identity.

- Advances in science have made these procedures safer and more accessible
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Biology and Gender Identity Development

Many factors influence how a person develops a sense of self

Gender identity development — the sense of feeling male, female, or something else may interact with:

- **Internal cues** — signals from the brain
 - **External forces** — parents, peers, media, and environment
 - **Hormonal influence?** — believed to contribute, but difficult to study
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Transgender and Cisgender Identities

Transgender — self-identification and behavior do not match traditional gender role for their assigned sex

- Used as an umbrella term for gender diversity and trans men / trans women
- Some also identify as other, agender, third gender, or genderqueer

Pronouns — societal impact grows as LGBTQIA+ visibility increases

- Some reject labels or use neutral pronouns like they/them or zie
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Transgender and Cisgender Identities

Transgender individuals — typically have usual genitals at birth; reassignment is not required

- Transgender youth
- Often face prejudice and discrimination related to their identity

Transphobia — fear and hatred of transgender people.

Gender Confirmation

Many transgender people seek to affirm their gender identity by changing biological sex

Gender nonconformity vs gender dysphoria.

- **Gender nonconformity** — gender identity, role, or expression differs from cultural norms
- **Gender dysphoria** — discomfort or distress from mismatch between gender identity and assigned sex at birth
 - Can lead to anxiety, depression, and rejection of assigned sex



Gender Confirmation

Medical transition — gender-affirming surgery is not automatic on request

Evaluation required — diagnosis of gender dysphoria and assessment by qualified professionals

Standards of care — most follow WPATH guidelines for surgery eligibility

Typical requirements

- Sustained hormone therapy (usually ~12 months unless medically contraindicated)
 - Living in affirmed gender role for a period (historically 12 months)
 - Letters from mental health professionals confirming readiness and informed consent
 - Demonstrated stable mental health and understanding of risks/outcomes
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Gender Confirmation: Male-to-Female (MTF) Procedures

MTF hormone therapy —with estrogen—has both permanent and temporary effects.

MTF surgical procedures can include

- **Orchiectomy**—removal of the testes.
 - **Vaginoplasty**—construction of a vagina, clitoris, and vulva.
 - Breast augmentation.
 - **Reduction thyroid chondroplasty** — alters appearance of the Adam's apple
 - Voice surgery.
 - Facial feminization.
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Gender Confirmation: Female-to-Male (FTM) Procedures

FTM hormonal therapy—with testosterone—has both permanent and temporary effects.

FTM surgical procedures can include

- Chest reconstruction/bilateral mastectomy.
 - **Hysterectomy/oophorectomy** — removal of uterus and ovaries
 - **Metoidioplasty**—construction of male-appearing genitalia.
 - **Phalloplasty**—construction of a phallus.
 - **Scrotoplasty**—construction of a scrotum.
 - **Urethroplasty**—creation of urethral canal in penis.
 - **Vaginectomy**—removal of the vagina.
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Androgyny (Gender Nonconforming/ Non-Binary/Genderqueer)

Androgyny — person with a high degree of both feminine (expressive) and masculine (instrumental) traits

Some argue androgyny is culture-bound

- **Gender stereotypes** — traditional ideas about what is masculine or feminine
 - Cultural variations
 - **What is masculine in one society may be considered feminine in another**
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Gender Roles

Gender roles — behaviors, attitudes, and characteristics that a society expects of males and females

- Societies' power differentials
- Ideas of what is “masculine” or “feminine”



**What are
examples of
gender roles?**

Gender Roles Across Time and Cultures

Gender roles revolve around issues of

- Security
- Reproduction
- Economic production

Gender socialization — the primary process by which society assigns meaning, attitudes, and behaviors to men and women

Social Institutions and Gender Role Development

Gender roles are shaped by societal forces in all areas of life

- Parents and caregivers
 - Peers
 - School
 - The media
 - Religion
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Sexism, Inequality, and Gender Roles

Sexism vs misogyny

Sexism — discrimination against people based on their sex

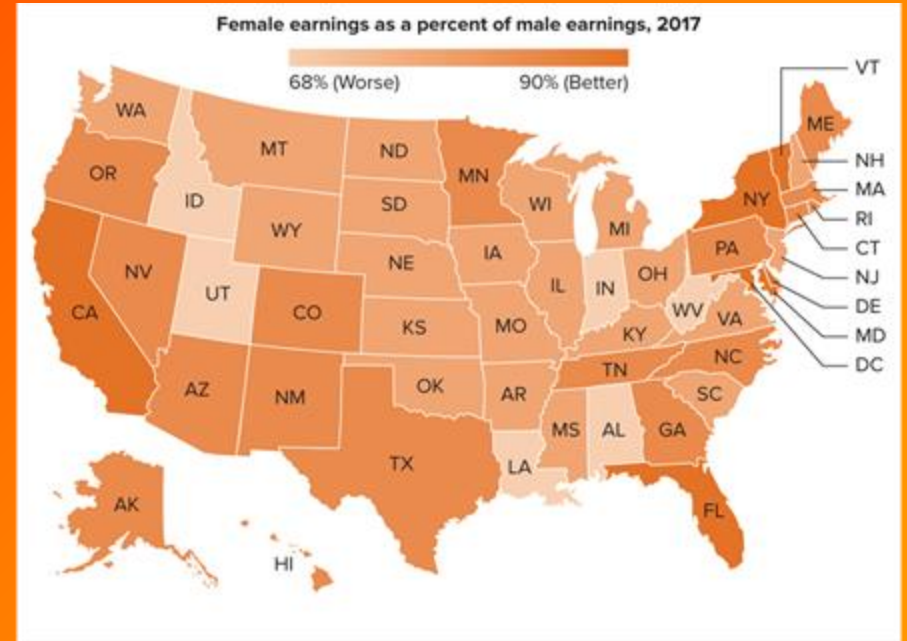
- Systematic oppression
- Male supremacy, superiority, and authority
- Gender violence

Misogyny — a hostile form of prejudice; hatred toward women

Figure 9.5

Inequity of female earnings

A map of U.S. states and the inequity of female earnings compared to those of men.



Gender Norms and Variance

Gender nonconforming — individuals whose gender behaviors go beyond or oppose community norms

Gender variance — nonconforming behavior resulting from biology, culture, and individual traits (e.g., personality, temperament)

*Separate from gender fluidity and transgender

Gender Identity and Intersex Rights: Well-Being and Social Justice

Protection of human rights to prevent discrimination

Every individuals is entitled to basic human rights and dignity

Activity – Gender Roles

Groups: 4–5 students

Instructions: Using the children’s storybooks provided, read the book as a group and discuss the following reflection questions.

Reflection Questions:

- Who were the main characters? What genders were they? If gender was not explicitly stated, what can be assumed?
 - How were boys/men portrayed compared to girls/women?
 - Were expectations about behavior, emotions, or appearance tied to gender?
 - Did the story reinforce or challenge traditional gender norms?
 - Which gender roles were most commonly reinforced?
 - How might these early messages influence attitudes toward gender and sexuality later in life?
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Questions?